

How Asia can contribute to world peace Psychology

The region of Asia has traditionally been acknowledged as a place of peace and harmony, respecting diversity and creating harmony between human–God, human–human, and human–nature. Asia has also been regarded by many as the cradle of civilization. Many world religions and great faiths have major strongholds in the continent of Asia: from Hinduism and Buddhism, to Jewish, Christianity, Islam, and other faiths such as Shinto and Taoism. All strongly support and encourage their adherents to promote justice and create peace among all fellow human beings on earth. All Asian-born diverse religions and faiths convey the same message of peace: inner peace or salaam (Islam) and shalom (Jewish); peace, love, and mercy (Christianity); avoidance of violence or ahimsa (Hinduism); and absence of all chaos or nirvana (Buddhism).

However, it is disheartening to witness that Asia too is not immune to violent tensions and conflicts that have become key features that characterize many regions of the world. Direct and structural violence in the form of genocides, human trafficking, political and economic injustices such as poverty and corruption, ethno-political conflicts, and environmental conflicts, to name but a few, are occurring within underdeveloped and developing countries of Asia. Religiously nuanced conflict is also more common nowadays and has torn many Asian societies apart.

We should also note the increasing use of armed violence as an instrument to both resolve problem and achieve political objectives. We continue to witness the display of military prowess as an instrument of problem-solving by major powers such as the United States and its allies against countries unwilling to support the so-called Western hegemony. Global injustice pervades. As a result, violent conflicts erupted, making peace even more elusive. India, China, Tibet, Pakistan, Philippines, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, Myanmar, and Taiwan are only a few examples where conflicts that take place in various geopolitical realms are quite latent, manifest, and protracted. Religions too have warned us about the potentials of human beings in shedding darkness, aside from illuminating lights into humanity. Islam, for instance, warns us that human beings have an intrinsic tendency to do harm and damage on earth. The Qur'an cites dialogue between God and angels on the divine plan to create human being, the first and the only creature equipped with a free mind and a free will. Qur'an states in the chapter of al-Baqarah 29–30:

But there is hope. I do believe that instead, we shall hold on to the conviction that we, as women and men of faith, never give up in our struggle to help the creation of positive peace in our region and the world. We should continue to pursue our common dream of a new world civilization based on social justice, equality, harmony, and prosperity. Various initiatives in these areas show that religions and religious leaders do have a positive role in the pursuit of justice and the building of peaceful communities. Deeply committed religious people are poised to take leaderships in the cause of reconciliation and service to the poor and disenfranchised. Religion does serve as a source of values and norms that could provide guidance for a peaceful and just world based on mutual understanding, mutual respect, and equality. Again, as an example from Islam, the Qur'an outlines in the chapter of al-Maidah: "O ye who believe! Stand out firmly for Allah, as witnesses to fair dealing, and let not the hatred of others to you make you swerve to wrong and depart from justice. Be just: that is next to piety: and fear Allah. For Allah is well-acquainted with all that ye do." There will be no peace without justice and no justice without persons enjoying basic human rights. One way of achieving such objective is to work collaboratively not only to eradicate violence, but also to promote and advance the vision of

shared security. The attainment of the vision of shared security, adopted at the Religions for Peace Eight World Assembly in Kyoto in August 2006, is not an easy task. However, it is a common obligation of all sectors in the society – the governments, civil societies, business community, and religious communities – to strive for the attainment of shared security at all levels: within a community, between communities, among the community of nation-states, and more importantly, among different civilizations and people of different faiths. It is in light of all the above considerations, this important book cannot be more relevant and timely in offering understandings of violence and conflict in the Asian context. As a new, emerging discipline, peace psychology has started to give a meaningful contribution to peacebuilding and peacemaking for diverse Asian communities.

Respect for human rights, and a democratic political order, are the paths that all of us should take in the Asian region. Human rights and freedom are the essence of all religious teachings: human beings should be liberated from exploitation by other human beings. The creation of political, economic, and cultural orders that ensure and respect human dignity in all three arenas – local, regional, and global – should be made a priority by both Asian state actors and civil societies.

